

THE PERNIL PLAYBOOK

El manual del pernil

The slow-roasted pork shoulder playbook: marinade, roast timeline, and the table it anchors.

Mainland-tested · From the Ortiz kitchen

Hecho con corazón y sofrito · sofritostudio.com

Pernil Asado — Slow-Roasted Puerto Rican Pork Shoulder Recipe

Pernil

Slow-roasted pork shoulder with crispy skin and garlicky mojo criollo. The Nochebuena centerpiece.

Ingredients

- 1 bone-in pork shoulder (8-10 lbs)
- 8 cloves garlic, mashed into a paste
- 1/4 cup olive oil
- 2 tablespoons dried oregano
- 1 tablespoon black pepper
- 1 tablespoon salt
- 2 tablespoons white vinegar
- 1/4 cup sofrito

Steps

1. Score the pork skin in a crosshatch pattern with a sharp knife, cutting through the fat but not into the meat.
2. Make the mojo criollo: mash garlic with oregano, pepper, salt, vinegar, olive oil, and sofrito into a thick paste.
3. Rub the paste all over the pork, working it under the skin and into every crevice.
4. Cover tightly and refrigerate overnight (at least 8 hours) to let the marinade penetrate.
5. Roast at 375°F for about 4 hours, basting every hour, until the internal temperature reaches 185°F and the skin is crackling-crispy.
6. Let rest for 20 minutes before carving. The juices redistribute and the skin stays crisp.

Arroz con Gandules — Authentic Puerto Rican Rice and Pigeon Peas Recipe

Arroz Con Gandules

Puerto Rico's national dish — rice, pigeon peas, and sofrito. The one-pot meal every boricua makes for holidays.

Ingredients

- 2 cups long-grain rice
- 1 can (15 oz) gandules (pigeon peas), drained
- 1/4 cup sofrito
- 2 tablespoons vegetable oil
- 1 packet sazón con culantro y achiote
- 1 teaspoon ground cumin
- 2.5 cups chicken broth
- 1/2 cup manzanilla olives with pimento
- Salt to taste

Steps

1. Heat oil in a large caldero or heavy pot over medium heat. Add sofrito and sauté for 2 minutes until fragrant.
2. Add drained gandules and cook for 3 minutes, stirring occasionally.
3. Stir in sazón and cumin. Cook for 1 minute to bloom the spices.
4. Add rice and stir to coat every grain in the sofrito mixture.
5. Pour in chicken broth, add olives, and bring to a boil. Stir once, then reduce heat to low.
6. Cover tightly and cook for 25 minutes without lifting the lid. Fluff with a fork before serving.

Habichuelas Guisadas — Authentic Puerto Rican Stewed Beans Recipe

Habichuelas

The everyday Puerto Rican side dish — thick, savory bean stew with calabaza that accompanies rice on virtually every plate.

Ingredients

- 2 cans (15 oz) pink beans
- 1/4 cup sofrito
- 2 tablespoons tomato paste
- 1/2 cup pumpkin (calabaza) cubed
- 1 packet sazón con culantro y achiote
- 1 teaspoon cumin
- 1 cup water
- 2 tablespoons oil
- Salt to taste

Steps

1. Heat oil in a medium pot over medium heat. Add sofrito and sauté for 3 minutes until fragrant and softened.
2. Add tomato paste and cook for 1 minute, stirring constantly to caramelize it slightly.
3. Toss in the cubed pumpkin, sazón, and cumin. Stir to coat the pumpkin in the flavor base.
4. Add the beans (with their liquid) and water. Stir well and bring to a boil.
5. Reduce heat and simmer for 20 minutes until the pumpkin is fork-tender and the broth has thickened.
6. Mash some of the pumpkin pieces against the side of the pot to thicken the stew. Taste and adjust salt before serving.